



Leonardo da Vinci's "tank"

In 1482, artist and inventor Leonardo da Vinci moved from Florence to Milan and bid for the patronage of Milanese nobleman Ludovico Sforza. He drew out some ideas in his sketchbooks, and his "war car" design—seen here alongside another weapon design—is regarded as one of the precursors of the tank.

KEY ELEMENTS

Da Vinci wrote to Sforza, "I can make armored cars, safe and unassailable, which will enter the closed ranks of the enemy... behind these our infantry will be able to follow quite unharmed." The idea of an armored battle car dates back to antiquity, and Da Vinci drew inspiration from this, combining

three elements—firepower (cannons firing from loopholes), protection (wooden and metal walls), and mobility (four men turning large cranks to power the wheels). The design looks surprisingly modern in shape, with angled surfaces to deflect incoming projectiles. However, the technology of the era would not have supported practical construction, and modern recreations of the design have shown that it could only have moved on a very flat surface, something unlikely to have been found on contemporary battlefields.

Leonardo da Vinci's sketch of a "war car" was among the early explorations of the idea of a land weapon combining armor, mobility, and firepower.

